

Journey to a Full-Time Trader

When and how to go full-time

When can you become a full-time trader?

Four rules. If all four are true for you, go ahead.

The four rules

We will take these one at a time.

01 You can generate 2x your monthly income from trading

Income, not expenses. At a 1 lakh income that is roughly 1.25 crore of capital.

02 Either the skill is proven, or you have the runway to build it

2 years of real, tracked performance - or 3 years of expenses sitting outside the trading account.

03 You have a real Plan B if it does not work

Something specific to go back to, still current, still warm. No Plan B, no full-time.

04 The people around you are genuinely okay with it

Spouse, children, parents. The point of the money was a peaceful life.

Rule 1

You can generate 2x your monthly income from trading.

Income. Not expenses.

- Your income has to cover everything - expenses, insurance, investments, savings, retirement
- Why 2x and not 1x: trading income swings, a bad quarter is normal, and your costs rise every year

The math, for a 1 lakh income

Your monthly income today	1,00,000
2x, the target from trading	2,00,000 per month
Per year, in hand	24,00,000
Gross needed, before tax	about 30,00,000

Trading profits are taxed as business income. There is no employer, no TDS, no standard deduction.

So how much capital do you need?

To generate 30 lakh a year:

Annual return on capital

Capital you need

36%

83 lakh

24%

1.25 crore

18%

1.67 crore

12%

2.5 crore

36% a year, sustained, is not conservative. It is top-decile performance. Pick the row you can honestly defend.

Rule 2

Either the skill is ready, or you have the runway to build it.

Skill is ready

- At least 2 years of real, tracked performance
- With real money, not backtests or paper trades
- Including a bad stretch - two good years in a trending market proves nothing

Runway to build it

- 3 years of living expenses set aside
- Sitting outside the trading account, untouchable
- This is separate from your trading capital, not part of it

Rule 3

Do you have a Plan B?

- If trading does not work out, what exactly do you go back to?
- Is that skill still current? Is that network still warm?
- Does your life get wrecked if this fails - or does it just get harder for a while?
- No Plan B, no full-time. That is the whole rule.

Rule 4

Are the people around you actually okay with this?

- Your spouse, your children, your parents
- They live with the uncertainty too, but without the screen in front of them
- A decision that makes money and creates permanent anxiety at home has not made you richer
- The point of the money was a peaceful life. Do not lose the point.

All four, together

If all four are true for you, go ahead. If even one is not, then not yet.

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But should you?

Everything above tells you when it is possible.

This part asks whether it is a good idea.

Start one step further back

Why do you want to trade?

To make money.

Why do you want to make money?

To live a happy, peaceful, secure life.

Today, tomorrow, and for the rest of it.

So what does an income have to give you?

Stability

Money arrives, month after month, in a range you can count on

Predictability

You know roughly what next month and next year look like

Recoverability

If it stops, you can rebuild it or replace it

Now ask yourself: does trading give you these three?

Stability?

No.

- Some months are excellent. Some months are bad, and not because you did anything wrong
- A losing quarter is normal. Four, five, six losing months happen to good traders
- The market decides your salary, and it does not consult you
- And the instability is not only financial - it is emotional, every single month

Predictability?

No.

- You cannot tell me what you will earn next month
- You cannot tell me what you will earn next year
- You cannot plan an EMI, a school fee, or a wedding against it with any confidence
- Every other income in your life has a date attached. This one does not.

Recoverability?

No. And this is the serious one.

Lose a job

You find another job. The skill transfers, the network exists, someone will vouch for you.

A business fails

You still have employable skills, customers, vendors, a team, a track record people can verify.

Trading fails

The skills you built trading your own money do not make you employable, and they do not help you build anything else.

And you do not control any of the rules

- The regulator can change what you are allowed to trade
- The exchange can change expiry days, lot sizes, and contract structure
- Weekly options can shrink or disappear
- Taxes and transaction costs can go up overnight
- Liquidity and market structure can shift and take your edge with them

None of this is hypothetical. All of it has already happened in the last two years.

And almost nobody does this successfully

87.7%

of individual F&O traders lost money in FY26

91,685 cr

lost by individual traders in that one year

7.2%

made any profit at all across FY22 to FY24

1%

made more than 1 lakh in profit, after costs, over those three years

Source: SEBI studies on the equity derivatives segment, FY22-FY24 and FY26

**So should you become
a full-time trader?**

Now the good news.

None of that was meant to discourage you.

This is exactly where the beauty of trading shows up.

Trading is the rare income you can build part-time

A business needs

Capital, infrastructure, people, customers, vendors, relationships, and your physical presence

A job needs

Someone to hire you, fixed hours, a place to be, and a boss

Trading needs

You, a strategy, and time to monitor it and make it better

That is why trading can run alongside your life instead of replacing it.

And automation closes the rest of the gap

- Learn properly, then build strategies that are actually yours
- Automate the execution so the market hours do not need you at the screen
- Review in the evening - what worked, what did not, what to fix
- Improve it, redeploy it, repeat

The work moves to evenings and weekends. The trading happens without you sitting there.

So you keep everything

- Your primary income keeps its stability, predictability and recoverability
- Trading income sits on top of it, as extra
- A bad trading quarter changes your year, not your life
- And you get to build the skill properly, without the pressure of needing it to pay this month

This is not the compromise version. For most people, this is the better version.

And one day, you may simply become a full-time trader.

Not by quitting anything.

The capital crossed the line on its own, the record accumulated,
your Plan B stayed warm - and the salary just became the smaller number.

What to take away

- There is no merit in becoming a full-time trader for the sake of being one
- There is enormous merit in becoming a good trader who makes real income from it
- Make that your goal instead - a serious part-time trader with a growing, tested edge
- If the four rules line up later, the choice is yours to make
- And if that day never comes, nothing is lost. You were already earning from it.

Questions

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